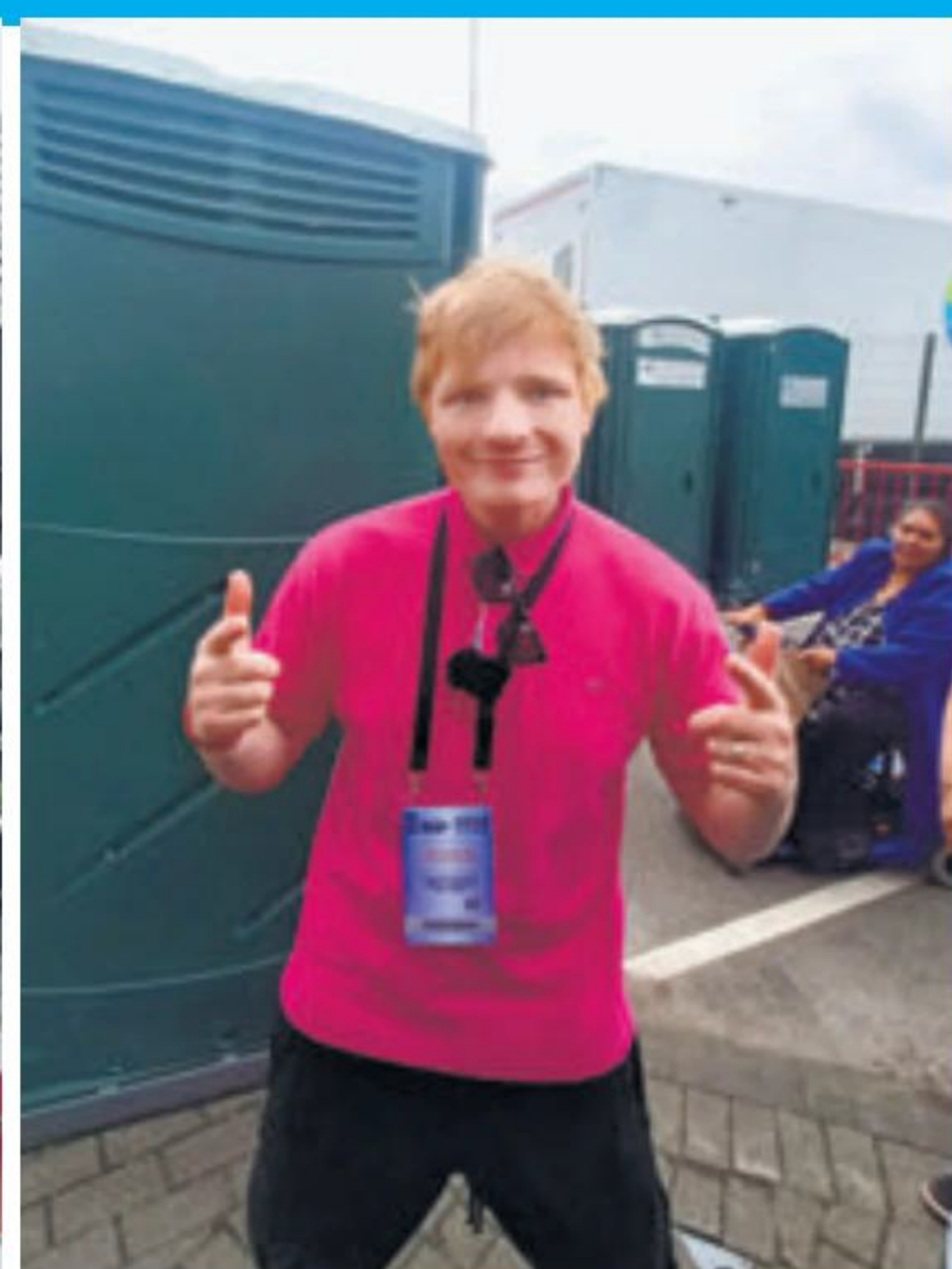
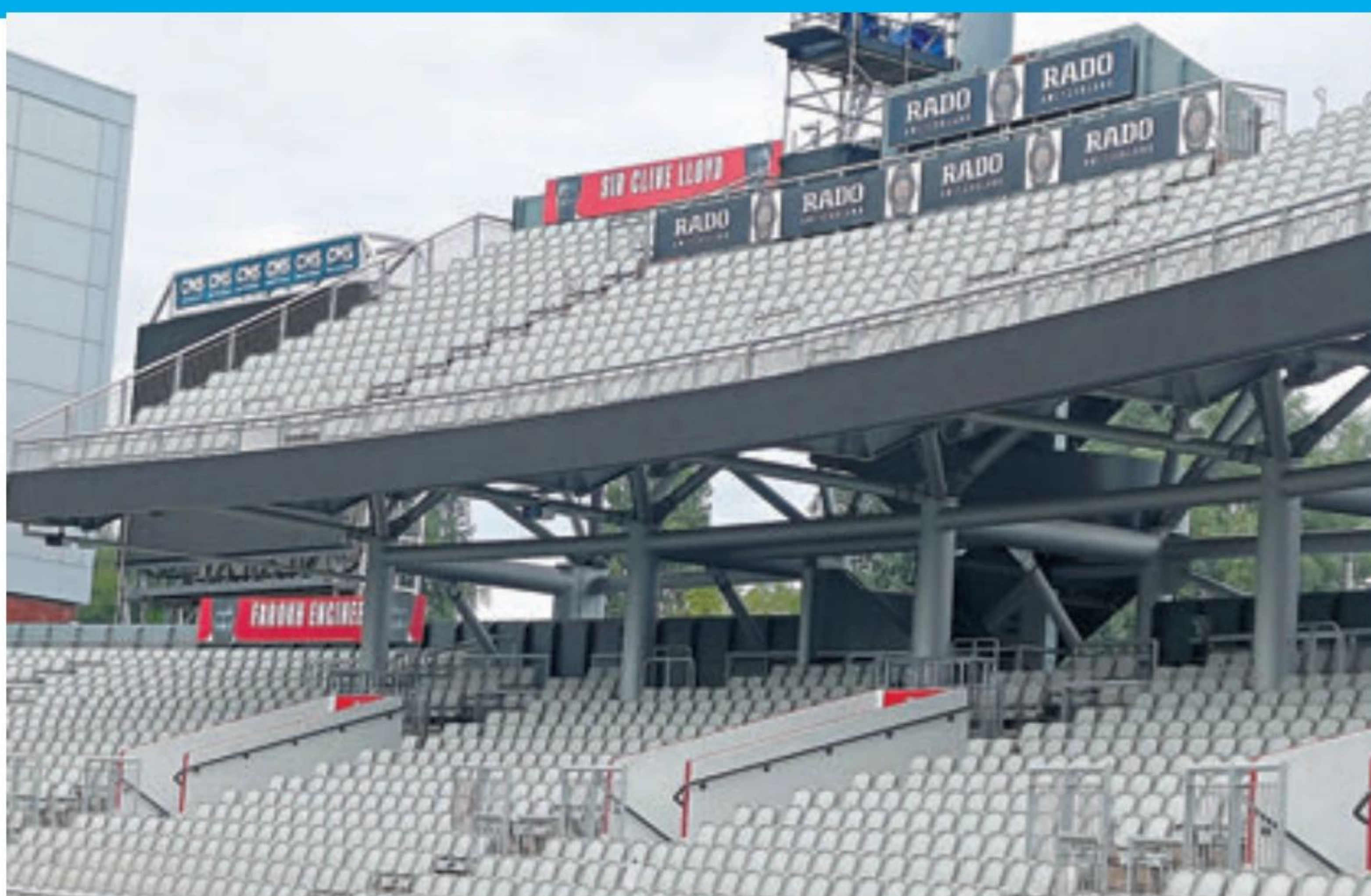




Engineer played 175 matches in nine seasons, scoring 5,942 runs, while Lloyd scored 30 First-Class centuries during his 18-season spell.

As he looked at his picture near the gate, it was a walk down memory lane for Engineer. "We had the best one-day team at Lancashire, and Clive and I played together for years, so we have many fond memories. And it feels so good that the club has recognised our efforts," he said.

A twist in the tale

Ed Sheeran loves cricket. His social media handles are proof that he has attended several cricket fixtures across the globe. So, as he walked around Old Trafford during the lunch break on the final day of the fourth Test, he received endless requests for selfies and autographs. That's only natural for such a global icon.

But then, there was a twist in the tale.

As the requests grew, came a revelation: the man everyone thought was Ed Sheeran was actually his doppelgänger — Ty Jones, a 30-year-old social media 'influencer'.

"I'm used to such requests, and I quite enjoy them," Jones told the Diary as he went on signing autographs and posing for pictures with a group of Indian fans.

Jones lives in Urmston, Manchester, with his wife Amanda and daughter Cherry, and enjoys this 'celebrity life'. In fact, he has travelled around cities for gigs and, over the years, his social media following has

increased significantly. "It's a strange thing because I often get treated like an actual celebrity. But then, the paycheque is definitely nowhere near as much," he said, adding with a smile: "So, it's like living a normal life with the status of being a celebrity. That's kind of a weird combination..."

This was Jones' first visit to a cricket stadium, and he was overwhelmed by the love and appreciation he received from spectators. "They all thought I was indeed the real Ed Sheeran, so they kept telling me how much they loved his music. That was such a lovely feeling," he said.

"While I enjoy this attention, I also tell people that I just look like him, but I'm not Ed. Even then, they click selfies and shower me with love. That's a huge blessing..."

Food for thought

One of the major perks of an overseas assignment is exploring global cuisine. Manchester, with its large South Asian diaspora, has some of the finest curry restaurants. Not long ago, when cricket teams from India, Pakistan or Sri Lanka came on long tours, some of these curry houses were the go-to spots

Faux fame: Not quite Ed, but close enough for a selfie swarm at Old Trafford. SHAYANACHARYA

for cricketers and support staff. Back then, of course, there were fewer dietary restrictions, and players enjoyed a good meal after a hard day's play.

But times have changed. While teams now have specific dietary preferences, several players also request customised food. That's perhaps why the curry restaurants didn't see any visits from current players. Some former cricketers and commentators, however, did visit the iconic Akbar's restaurant on Liverpool Street for some '*desi*' food.

A staff member at the restaurant told the Diary, "During the 2019 World Cup, the Afghanistan team visited us regularly, and so did other teams. But this time, even though fans turned up in large numbers, no players from the teams were here..."

The media fraternity, however, remained regulars at these curry restaurants — in need of their daily dose of '*desi*' food after spending the whole day at the media centre.

« The 'Ed Sheeran' at Old Trafford was really Ty Jones, a 30-year-old social media influencer »